

‘How Crater Lake came to be’: A Klamath Indian legend Special for the Herald and News – February 25, 2002

 craterlakeinstitute.com/crater-lake-new-archives/2002-2/2002-02-6

‘How Crater Lake came to be’: A Klamath Indian legend Special for the Herald and News
Herald and News

Klamath Falls, Oregon February 25, 2002

By BARBARA ALATORRE One day, Great Spirit Beings pushed ice through a hole in the sky to build a great mountain, Moyaina (Mount Mazama). Then the spirits climbed down to Earth and created the Klamath terrain by digging tunnel-like caverns beneath the earth and pushing up the Cascade Range. Hundreds of rivers, marshes and lakes emerged from underground, and trees, meadows and plants sprang up everywhere.

All of the Spirits returned to the Nolis-Gaeni, the afterworld, except the Spirit chief Gmo’Kamc, who made a new home inside Mlaiksi (Mount Shasta). Gmo’Kamc created human beings to live on the lake shores around him: the Klamath Lake People, the Modoc Lake People (Modoc Lake is now called Tule Lake), and Yahooskni People on the water now known as Goose Lake.

Chief of the Below World, Monadalkni, envied Gmo’Kamc’s beautiful Indian domain and return many times to watch the Ma’Klaks. One day he spied an extraordinary maiden surrounded by brave warriors who wanted to marry her. Loha was the daughter of the Klamath chief, and she refused to marry anyone. Still, Monadalkni dispatched Skooks, his trusted emissary, to propose on his behalf.

On the night of the Ma’Klaks coming-out ceremony, Skooks suddenly appeared, hooded in dark wolf skin. Interrupting a ceremonial dance, he stepped before Loha and her family bearing lavish gifts: beaver pelts, valuable feathers of the red woodpecker, horses and white deerskins. “My Chief sends these offerings for your hand in everlasting marriage,” he said. “Eternal life will be yours as you become one and live in a big mountain abode forever.”

As Skooks’ hideous crimson red eyes gaped at the maiden, the Ma’Klaks of the village watched her other suitors disappear in a flash of orange light. Loha raced to her father’s

tule lodge crying out, “No, I don’t want to live in a mountain!” The Klamath chief quickly called elders and medicine men to council in his lodge. They decided that Loha must be whisked away to their Modoc brothers to the south.

Skooks returned the next night demanding Loha’s whereabouts, but no one in the tribe would speak. When Monadalkni learned of the maiden’s disappearance, he shook with violent anger and threatened fiery vengeance on Loha’s people. Monadalkni began running back and forth in the passageways beneath Moy-yaina, throwing lightning bolts and causing the mountain to explode with such force that molten lava rained like hot pitch upon the People of the Lakes. Giant fireballs shot out of the mountain as it erupted in deafening booms — five times in succession! Women and children took refuge in Klamath Lake, crying and calling out for the Great Spirit to save them.

Monadalkni ran to the top of the mountain and faced Gmo’Kamc. They fought enraged, silhouetted against the red glow illuminating the rumbling Cascades. The good chief finally forced the Chief of the Below World back underground and collapsed the mountaintop onto the entrance of the underworld. A huge crater remained where the peak used to be.

Medicine men sang their sacred songs for rain to put out the fires. The rains came, filling the crater with water and creating the lake called Gii-was. Cradled in the bosom of Tum-sum-ne (Klamath/Modoc for “the big mountain with top cut off”), Gii-was became a holy place the Ma’Klaks kept secret for more than 7,000 years, until one day in 1852 when a white man accidentally discovered it.

In 1902, Gii-was became Crater Lake National Park.

Other pages in this section

- **Park ranger recognized for rescue efforts – December 15, 2002**
- **Crater Lake ranger presented with Exemplary Act Award – December 07, 2002**
- **Obituaries – James Robert Read – November 24, 2002**
- **Plan: Relocate rim parking: Rim Village parking may leave Crater Lake’s edge – November 22, 2002**
- **Snow closes Crater Lake’s Rim Drive – November 13, 2002**
- **Crater Lake symposium broad as well as deep – October 07, 2002**
- **Renowned oceanographer featured speaker at Crater Lake symposium – September 18, 2002**
- **Rex Lee Trulove – September 08, 2002**

- **Crater Lake Fascinations: Diller's pin, clear water, fish stories keep lake and park a place of wonder forever fascinating – August 31, 2002**
- **Navy pilot drops in to Crater Lake, again – August 27, 2002**
- **Crater Lake centennial party: Celebration amid the smoke – August 26, 2002**
- **Celebration day: Crater Lake National Park transformed for festivities – August 25, 2002**
- **Crater Lake license plate available in Oregon – August 25, 2002**
- **Happy 100th to the gem of Klamath – August 23, 2002**
- **Crater Lake learning center dedicated – August 23, 2002**
- **Long lines expected for new license plates – August 23, 2002**
- **National Park Service leader pays return visit to Crater Lake – August 23, 2002**
- **Crater Lake events listed – August 22, 2002**
- **Larson honored for Crater Lake work – August 18, 2002**
- **Obituary: Howard 'Bud' Hittenrauch – August 15, 2002**
- **Speakers set for Crater Lake – August 15, 2002**
- **Stunning revelations at high elevations: Runners experience life – August 11, 2002**
- **Lindgren makes memorable win – August 11, 2002**
- **Marathon has world, local flavor – August 11, 2002**
- **Runner takes 'stroll in park' – August 11, 2002**
- **Bush to visit Oregon, not Crater Lake – August 06, 2002**
- **Keep Rim Drive open – all of the way – July 31, 2002**
- **Crater Lake license plate unveiled – July 31, 2002**
- **Dedication of Future Science & Learning Center – August 22, 2002**
- **The fight for Crater Lake/Winning National Park Status Wasn't Easy – July 28, 2002**
- **Centennial Award goes to Crater Lake researcher – July 22, 2002**
- **The Crater Lake murders and the 9-fingered man – July 21, 2002**
- **The party is 'on' at Crater Lake – July 18, 2002**
- **Park plan looks at snipping Rim Road – July 05, 2002**
- **Controlled burns set for Monday at Crater Lake – June 16, 2002**
- **Controlled burns set for Monday at Crater Lake – June 15, 2002**
- **Crater Lake's north entrance open – June 05, 2002**
- **Crater Lake looking at trail relocation, rehabilitation – June 05, 2002**
- **Lake retains beauty after 100 years – May 22, 2002**
- **Crater Lake National Park Centennial 'Let the celebration begin' 1902-2002 – May 21, 2002**

- **The jewel turns 100: a century after it was dedicated, Crater Lake National Park inspires wonder for millions – May 19, 2002**
- **Old stories about W. F. Arant and Steel come back again and again for family – May 13, 2002**
- **W.F. Arant – Crater Lake’s first superintendent – May 13, 2002**
- **Quilting Crater Lake: Rocky Point will raffle quilt to raise funds – May 12, 2002**
- **Crater Lake alumni sought – May 09, 2002**
- **Cafe at Crater Lake to reopen – April 26, 2002**
- **Park Service names new concession official – April 13, 2002**
- **National park’s father returns: Will Steele on stage at Crater Lake – April 9, 2002**
- **Xanterra Parks & Resorts Receives Contract to Manage Concessions – April 5, 2002**
- **Crater Lake to be subject of museum lectures – March 30, 2002**
- **Crater Lake employee reunion part of Centennial celebration – March 25, 2002**
- **Making tracks at Crater Lake: guide shares insights with snowshoers; his knowledge of the lake is legendary – February 24, 2002**
- **Crater Lake Centennial Cookbook to be a part of this year’s celebration – February 22, 2002**
- **Crater Lake Ski Patrol crucial to park operations – February 21, 2002**
- **Crater Lake concession awarded to Amfac – January 30, 2002**
- **Lost skiers find searchers – January 24, 2002**
- **Search for overdue skiers – January 21, 2002**
- **Going postal for Crater Lake – January 13, 2002**